The University of Texas at Austin

Multimodal integration reveals complementary imaging and genetic predictors of coronary artery disease risk

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Take-home Cardiac imaging and polygenic risk capture complementary information about future CAD, improving risk stratification beyond clinical variables in UK Biobank.

Study design and imaging features

Clinical risk scores use a small set of traditional variables. We asked which imaging modalities add predictive information for incident coronary artery disease (CAD) beyond clinical, electrocardiogram (ECG) and genetic risk, and how imaging-derived and polygenic risk relate in the same people.

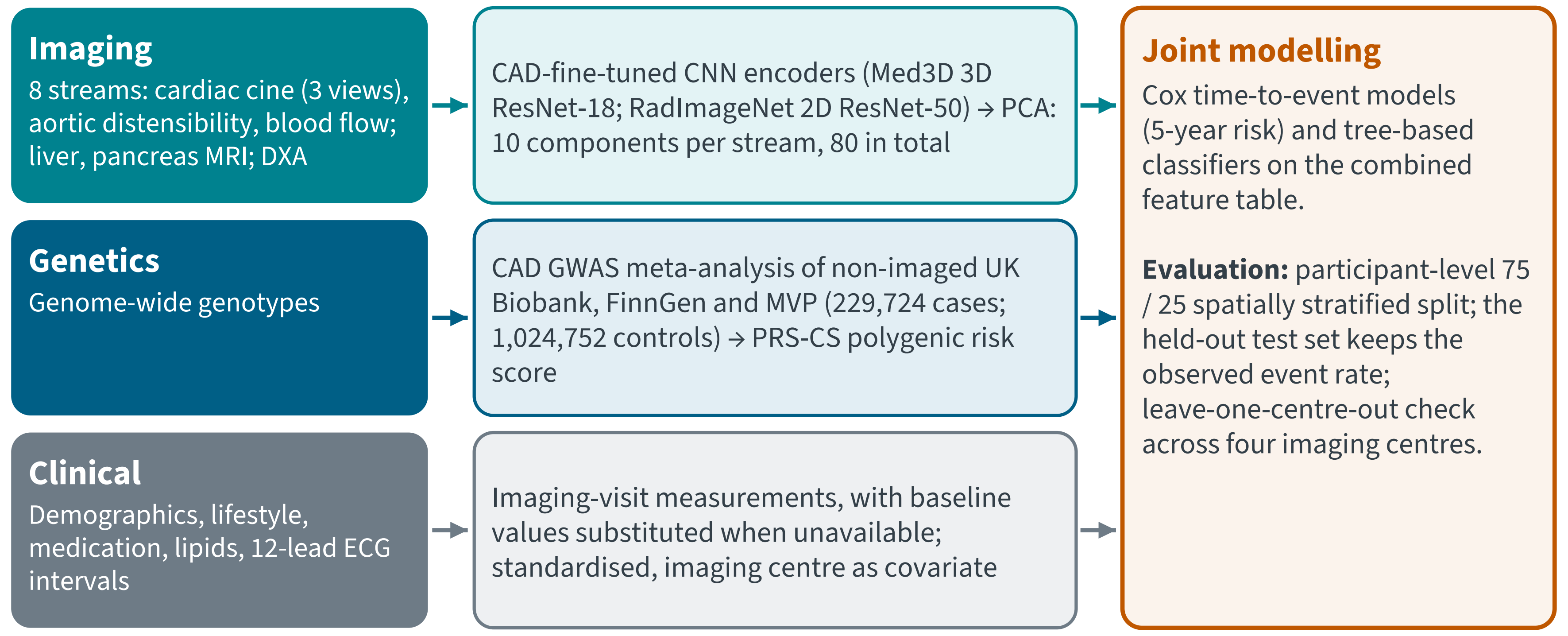
42,351
participants, UK Biobank imaging cohort

677
incident CAD cases (1.6% observed event proportion)

4.6 y
median follow-up; 5-year risk horizon

75 / 25
training 31,754 (499 events) / held-out test 10,597 (178 events)

Multimodal workflow



Imaging
8 streams: cardiac cine (3 views), aortic distensibility, blood flow; liver, pancreas MRI; DXA

→ CAD-fine-tuned CNN encoders (Med3D 3D ResNet-18; RadImageNet 2D ResNet-50) → PCA: 10 components per stream, 80 in total →

Genetics
Genome-wide genotypes

→ CAD GWAS meta-analysis of non-imaged UK Biobank, FinnGen and MVP (229,724 cases; 1,024,752 controls) → PRS-CS polygenic risk score →

Clinical
Demographics, lifestyle, medication, lipids, 12-lead ECG intervals

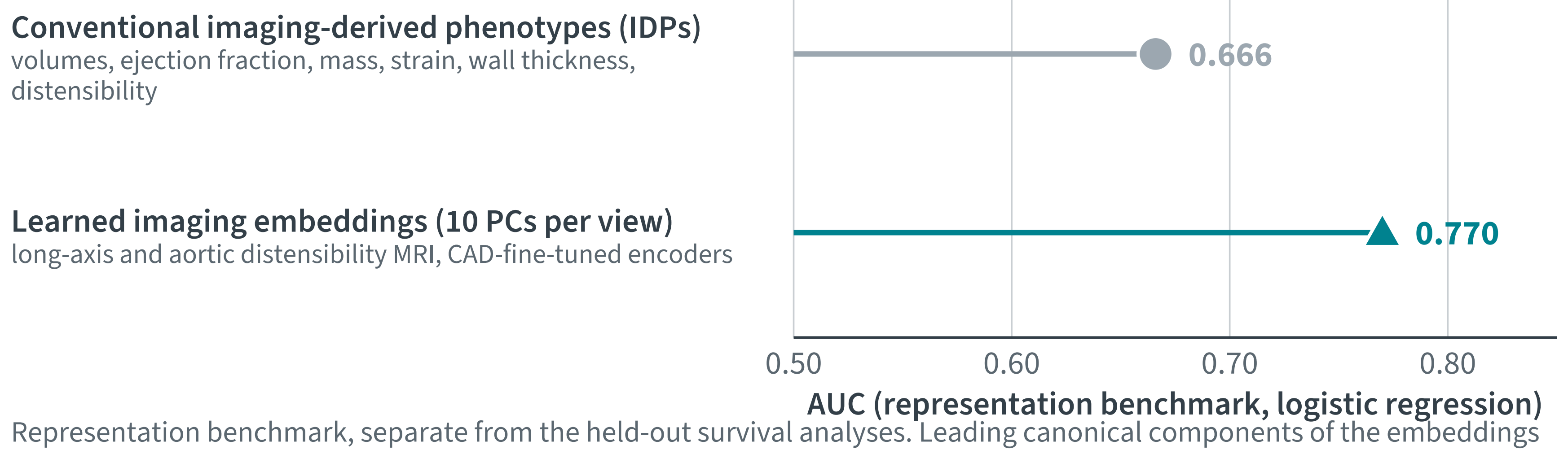
→ Imaging-visit measurements, with baseline values substituted when unavailable; standardised, imaging centre as covariate →

Joint modelling
Cox time-to-event models (5-year risk) and tree-based classifiers on the combined feature table.

Evaluation: participant-level 75 / 25 spatially stratified split; the held-out test set keeps the observed event rate; leave-one-centre-out check across four imaging centres.

Outcome: clinically recognised CAD (myocardial infarction, angina or ischaemic heart disease, coronary revascularisation) from linked records; first event after the imaging visit, prevalent CAD excluded. Cardiac MRI does not image coronary plaque. Encoders were fine-tuned on balanced case–control sets from the training partition only; all risk analyses keep the observed event rate. Genetically defined White British participants.

Learned imaging representations outperform conventional phenotypes

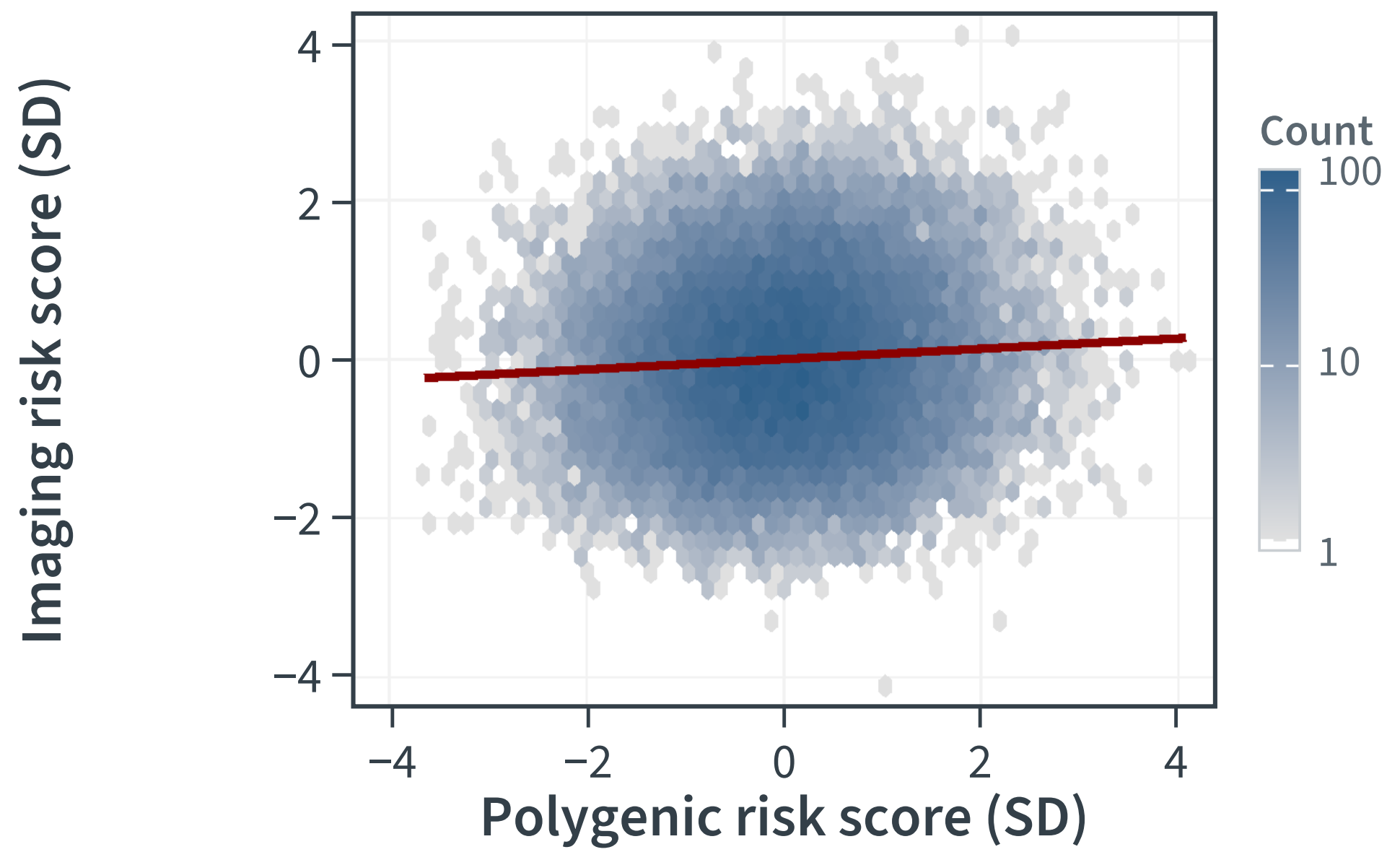


Representation benchmark, separate from the held-out survival analyses. Leading canonical components of the embeddings align with stroke volume, ejection fraction and myocardial mass (canonical correlations 0.79–0.84).

Imaging and genetics capture complementary risk

An imaging risk score (IRS; ridge-penalised Cox model on the 80 imaging principal components, five-fold cross-fitted) and the PRS both predict CAD, yet they barely overlap.

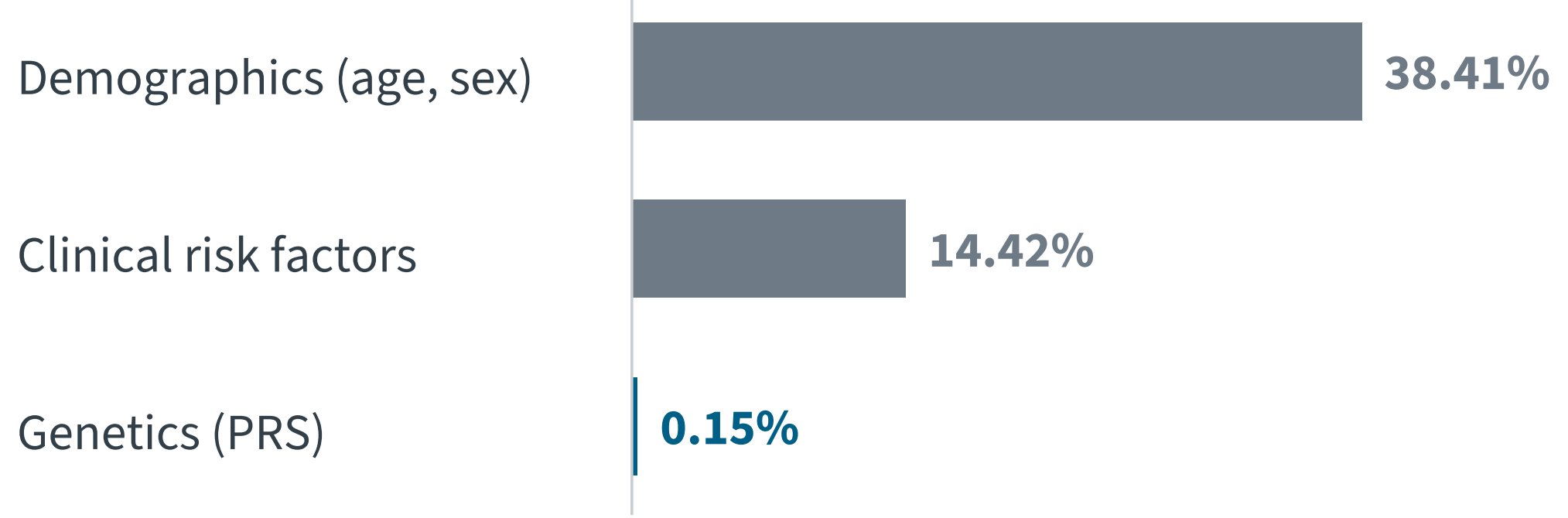
Weak PRS–imaging risk correlation



PRS–imaging risk correlation: r = 0.065; shared variance = 0.4%; n = 29,075.

Low overlap supports complementarity; it does not establish biological independence or show that imaging risk is wholly acquired.

Variance of the imaging risk score explained (partial R²)

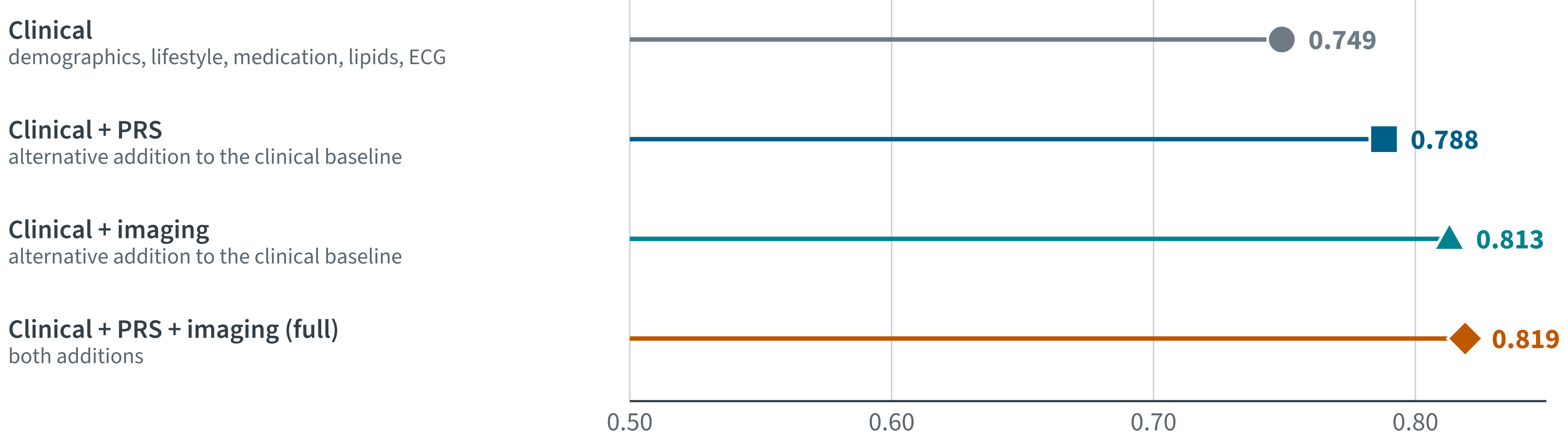


Which feature groups carry non-redundant information? (leave-one-group-out)

Largest loss when removed
- Long-axis cardiac MRI
- Medication history
- Polygenic risk score
- Aortic distensibility MRI

Little loss after clinical adjustment
- Liver MRI
- Pancreas MRI
- Whole-body DXA
- Blood-flow MRI

Held-out discrimination: full model 0.819 vs clinical 0.749 (absolute difference 0.070)



Nested Cox models, held-out test set (n = 10,597; 178 events). No confidence intervals are reported for these C-indices. Calibration slopes 0.99–1.08.

Combined models refine CAD risk

Sequential stratification of the held-out set: each tier keeps the top third of the previous tier, with the cut-point recalculated within that tier.

Tier 1
Top third by clinical-model risk
8.0%
5-year CAD incidence

→

Tier 2
Within Tier 1: top third by PRS
11.3%
5-year CAD incidence

→

Tier 3
Within Tier 2: top third by imaging risk score
15.9%
5-year CAD incidence

Within Tier 3, the top within-tier quintile of both PRS and imaging risk reached 36.8% five-year incidence; stratum size and confidence interval are not reported. For context, the crude event proportion in the full cohort is 1.6%.

Leave-one-centre-out evaluation within UK Biobank (not external validation)

Held-out centre	Test cases / controls	AUC	C-index
Reading	71 / 7,607	0.805	0.762
Cheadle	409 / 21,942	0.822	0.748
Bristol	82 / 3,307	0.785	0.751
Newcastle	115 / 8,740	0.795	0.732

Site-analysis models trained on three centres and tested on the fourth. Different feature set and validation design from the main held-out analysis.

Calibration, reclassification and accuracy (held-out)

0.634
continuous NRI, full vs clinical (95% CI 0.534–0.734)

5.5% → 9.5%
index of prediction accuracy, clinical → full

0.99–1.08
calibration slopes, all nested models

Full-model net benefit was highest at 5–30% threshold probabilities. Continuous NRI is not the share of people correctly reclassified.

Conclusion

Selected cardiac imaging (long-axis cine and aortic distensibility MRI) and genome-wide polygenic risk add partially non-overlapping information to clinical variables, improving discrimination and risk enrichment, with calibration slopes near 1.

Limitations

- Selected, complete-case, White British UK Biobank sample; absolute risks may not transport to other settings.
- No fully external validation; site robustness is within one cohort.
- No coronary calcium or CT-angiography benchmark; cardiac MRI does not image plaque.
- Observational prediction: clinical utility, test ordering and cost-effectiveness remain untested.
- Extreme-risk strata are small and their precision is not reported.

Data and code

UK Biobank data are available to approved researchers through application (this work: application 65439). Analysis and figure code: github.com/Devanshpandey/Multimodal-integration-for-coronary-artery-disease-risk-prediction (code only; no participant data or model weights). Genome-wide polygenic risk score; no individual gene-level discovery claims.

Preprint (earlier version)

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